DeepThought Assessment – Initial Analysis Notes

1. People Problems

Fear Culture

- Employees are afraid of being blamed.
- Supervisors avoid documenting actual root causes.
- Honest reporting may lead to public criticism.

Lack of Accountability

- Tasks are assigned to departments, not individuals.
- Nobody feels personal ownership of delayed activities.
- Issues remain unresolved for multiple days.

Resistance to Change

- Previous software adoption attempts failed.
- Employees prefer familiar tools like Excel.
- New systems are seen as additional work.

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2. Process Problems

Long Meetings

- Daily meeting is scheduled for 30 minutes.
- Actual duration is 60–90 minutes.
- Technical discussions consume meeting time.

No Daily Planning

- Monthly and weekly plans exist.
- Daily micro-planning does not exist.
- Teams react to issues instead of managing them proactively.

No Escalation System

- Red items remain unresolved.

- Escalation history is not tracked.
- No clear process exists for handling overdue tasks.

No Ownership Tracking

- Department names are shown instead of individual owners.
- Responsibility becomes unclear.
- Follow-up depends on Anil and Karthik.

No Unplanned Work Analysis

- Machine breakdowns and urgent requests are not categorized.
- Root causes of unplanned work are not tracked.
- Management cannot identify recurring patterns.

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3. Technology Problems

Alert System Limitations

- Alerts show status but not accountability.
- No trend analysis is available.
- No escalation information is shown.

Dashboard Limitations

- Dashboard focuses on reporting.
- Dashboard does not support decision-making.
- Dashboard lacks ownership visibility.

Failed Software Adoption

- Project management software implementation failed.
- Employees were unable to adapt.
- Organization returned to Excel-based systems.

Data Quality Issues

- Root cause fields are frequently blank.
- Generic entries reduce usefulness of reports.
- Poor data quality affects management decisions.

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4. Scaling Risks

Growth From 2 to 8 CDMO Projects

- Complexity will increase significantly.
- Existing manual coordination methods will not scale.

More Analysts

- Additional analysts will join.
- Lack of standard processes may create inconsistency.

Increased Dependencies

- More departments will become interconnected.
- Delays in one department can impact multiple projects.

Leadership Visibility Risk

- CEO already lacks operational visibility.
- Scaling will worsen the problem if systems remain unchanged.

Execution Risk

- Current system depends heavily on follow-ups.
- Anil and Karthik are acting as coordinators instead of system builders.
- The company may struggle to maintain execution quality during growth.

Key Insight

The core problem is not technology.

The company has already built trackers, dashboards, alerts, and automation.

The real challenge is the interaction between:

- Human behavior (fear, accountability, trust)
- Process design (planning, ownership, escalation)
- Technology (tools, dashboards, alerts)

Technology is exposing problems, but it is not changing behavior.

The company needs behavioral accountability systems supported by technology, not technology alone.

PART A – DIAGNOSIS

Situation A – The Alert Nobody Responds To

1. Stated Problem

The daily alert email is functioning correctly and reaches the CEO and COO every morning. However, the same red items remain unresolved for several days and nobody takes action or escalates the issue.

2. What Is Actually Going On?

The real problem is not the alert system. The problem is the absence of accountability and ownership.

The alerts identify which department has a problem but do not identify who is personally responsible for resolving it. As a result, no individual feels accountable for taking action.

The alert system is being used as a reporting tool rather than an execution tool. People receive information but are not required to respond, explain delays, or create recovery plans.

Over time, repeated alerts without consequences have reduced urgency. Employees have become accustomed to seeing red items without feeling pressure to resolve them.

3. Evidence

- The tracker shows department names instead of individual owners.
- The same red items remain unresolved for multiple days.
- Escalation history is not visible.
- Trend information is not available.
- The CEO stated that he still lacks visibility despite receiving daily alerts.

Situation B – The Blank Field

1. Stated Problem

Anil and Karthik believe employees are not disciplined enough to complete the root cause section in the deviation tracker.

2. What Is Actually Going On?

The real problem is a fear-based reporting culture.

Employees do not avoid filling root causes because they are careless. They avoid it because honest reporting may expose them or their managers to criticism during review meetings.

The root cause field has become associated with blame instead of learning. Employees believe that documenting the real issue creates personal risk, so they either leave the field blank or provide vague answers.

Anil and Karthik focused on compliance and discipline but did not investigate the emotional and cultural reasons behind the behavior.

3. Evidence

- Around 70% of root cause fields are blank or generic.
- One supervisor stated that honest reporting leads to excessive questioning.
- Another supervisor explained that a manager was publicly criticized after an honest root cause entry.
- Employees prefer silence because it feels safer than transparency.

Situation C – The Meeting That Eats the Day

1. Stated Problem

The daily status meeting is scheduled for 30 minutes but regularly lasts between 60 and 90 minutes.

2. What Is Actually Going On?

The meeting itself is not the primary problem.

The real issue is the absence of structured daily planning and work categorization.

The organization does not distinguish between routine work, planned work, and unplanned work. As a result, every issue gets pushed into the daily meeting.

The meeting has become a problem-solving session rather than a status review session. Technical discussions, deviations, and operational issues consume meeting time and create additional unplanned work for the rest of the day.

Because no daily micro-plans exist, employees operate reactively instead of proactively.

3. Evidence

- No daily planning system exists.
- Technical issues are discussed during status meetings.
- Twelve department heads attempt to discuss operational matters in a 30-minute meeting.
- Unplanned work is not categorized or tracked.
- The advisor identified that nobody measures the causes of unplanned work.

PART B – INTERVENTION DESIGN

Situation A – The Alert Nobody Responds To

1. First Conversation

I would first speak with the CEO and two department heads whose items frequently remain in RED status.

Questions:

- What prevents action after an alert turns red?
- What information do you need before taking action?
- Who should be accountable for each delayed task?

The goal is to understand why alerts are not leading to execution.

2. Changes During the First Two Weeks

- Assign an individual owner for every task.
- Introduce a daily accountability review.
- Define escalation rules for overdue tasks.
- Require owners to provide recovery plans for delayed items.
- Review only the top critical RED items instead of discussing everything.

3. Tool Design

What the User Sees

A dashboard containing:

- Task Name
- Owner Name
- Due Date
- Current Status
- Days Overdue
- Escalation Level
- Recovery Plan

Workflow

1. Task assigned to an individual.
2. Status updated daily.
3. Overdue tasks trigger escalation.
4. CEO and COO receive exception reports.

Technology

- Excel for tracking
- Power Automate for alerts
- Power BI dashboard for visibility

4. Buy-In Strategy

I would not start by explaining the dashboard.

I would show a supervisor how ownership visibility protects them from being blamed for delays caused by another department.

The message:
"This system is not designed to catch mistakes. It is designed to make dependencies visible so that unresolved issues can be escalated earlier."

Situation B – The Blank Field

1. First Conversation

I would privately meet supervisors and department heads.

Questions:

- What happens when someone reports the actual root cause?
- Why do people leave the field blank?
- What concerns do employees have about documenting issues?

2. Changes During the First Two Weeks

- Introduce no-blame root cause reviews.
- Focus discussions on process failures instead of individual failures.
- Reward transparency.
- Encourage learning from mistakes.

3. Tool Design

What the User Sees

Deviation Form:

- Incident Description
- Root Cause
- Corrective Action
- Preventive Action
- Responsible Owner
- Target Completion Date

Workflow

1. Deviation occurs.
2. Supervisor enters information.
3. Department head reviews.
4. Corrective actions tracked until closure.

Technology

- Microsoft Forms or Google Forms
- Excel database
- Power Automate reminders

4. Buy-In Strategy

I would use a real example where identifying the actual root cause prevented a future problem.

The discussion would focus on learning and prevention rather than accountability through punishment.

Situation C – The Meeting That Eats the Day

1. First Conversation

I would meet the COO and selected HODs.

Questions:

- Which discussions belong in the daily meeting?
- Which discussions should happen separately?
- What percentage of today's work was planned versus unplanned?

2. Changes During the First Two Weeks

- Separate technical review meetings from status meetings.
- Introduce daily micro-planning.
- Categorize work into:
    - Routine
    - Planned
    - Unplanned
- Track causes of unplanned work.

3. Tool Design

What the User Sees

Daily Planning Sheet:

- Planned Tasks
- Unplanned Tasks
- Time Spent
- Reason for Deviation

Workflow

1. Employee creates daily plan.
2. Unplanned activities are recorded.
3. Weekly review identifies patterns.
4. Recurring issues become improvement projects.

Technology

- Excel
- Google Sheets
- Power Automate

4. Buy-In Strategy

I would demonstrate how proper planning reduces firefighting and creates more control over daily work.

Rather than asking supervisors to do extra work, I would show them how the process saves time and reduces unnecessary follow-ups.

PART C – SCALE THINKING

1. What Breaks First When the Company Grows From 2 Projects to 8 Projects?

The most dangerous failure point is the lack of accountability and ownership.

Today, Anil and Karthik compensate for system weaknesses through constant follow-ups, reminders, coordination, and problem-solving. This approach may work with 2 active projects, but it will not scale to 8 projects.

As the number of projects increases:

- More tasks will be created.
- More cross-functional dependencies will emerge.
- More delays will occur.
- More meetings will be required.
- More follow-ups will be needed.

Without clear ownership, every issue will eventually be routed through analysts, creating a bottleneck.

The organization will become dependent on people chasing work instead of systems driving execution.

This is the first thing that will break because execution currently depends on individual effort rather than a repeatable system.

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2. What System Would I Build Today To Prevent That Breakdown?

I would build an Execution Accountability System during the first three months.

System Components

Individual Task Ownership

Every task must have:

- Owner Name
- Due Date
- Priority
- Current Status
- Escalation Level

Dependency Tracking

Each task should identify:

- Previous dependency
- Next dependency
- Blocking department

Escalation Framework

Level 1: Owner reminder

Level 2: Department Head notification

Level 3: COO escalation

Level 4: CEO visibility

Standard Project Templates

Every CDMO project should follow a standard structure:

- Project Milestones
- Deliverables
- Responsible Owners
- Risks
- Dependencies

This ensures consistency when more analysts join.

Weekly Execution Review

Instead of discussing every issue daily, conduct a weekly review focused on:

- Delayed items
- Root causes
- Repeated deviations
- Improvement opportunities

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3. What Should Be Automated And What Should Remain Human?

Automate

Status Collection

Employees update status once.

The system automatically generates:

- Dashboards
- Reports
- Alerts
- Escalation notifications

Reminders

Automatic reminders for:

- Overdue tasks
- Missing updates
- Pending approvals

Trend Analysis

Use AI and dashboards to identify:

- Frequently delayed activities
- Repeated deviations
- High-risk departments

Executive Reporting

Generate daily and weekly summaries automatically.

Keep Human

Root Cause Discussions

Root causes require judgment, context, and conversation.

AI cannot understand organizational politics, emotions, or trust issues accurately.

Coaching And Change Management

Supervisors need support and encouragement, not automation.

Building trust requires human interaction.

Conflict Resolution

Cross-functional disagreements should be resolved through discussion.

Strategic Decisions

Project prioritization, resource allocation, and leadership decisions should remain human responsibilities.

Why I Draw The Line Here

Technology should automate repetitive work and improve visibility.

Humans should handle trust, behavior, accountability, decision-making, and organizational change.

The goal is not to automate people.

The goal is to automate administrative effort so that people can focus on solving problems, building relationships, and improving execution.

A company that automates everything loses human judgment.

A company that automates nothing cannot scale.

The right balance is to automate information flow while keeping responsibility, communication, and decision-making human.

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     CEO WANTS VISIBILITY
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   |   Poor Visibility    |
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PSYCHOLOGY                    BUSINESS                    TECHNOLOGY

Fear of Blame           Delayed Decisions           Alerts & Dashboards
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Blank Root Causes ---> Poor Data Quality ---> Incomplete Insights
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No Accountability ---> Red Alerts Stay Open ---> No Action Taken
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   Ownership Missing                      Escalation Missing

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No Daily Planning ---> Long Meetings ---> Unplanned Work
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        v                  v                  v
   Reactive Culture   Time Waste       Execution Delays
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                    COMPANY GROWS (2 → 8 PROJECTS)
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                    More Dependencies
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                                v

                    More Delays
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                    System Breakdown


                       SOLUTION FRAMEWORK

People First
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Trust + Accountability
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     v
Structured Process
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     v
Technology Support
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Scalable Execution System